

On the Five Tiers

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The Sovereignty Papers

Essay No. 8: On the Five Tiers

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“In framing a government which is to be administered by men over men, the great difficulty lies in this: you must first enable the government to control the governed; and in the next place oblige it to control itself.”

— James Madison, *The Federalist No. 51* (1788)

I. The Problem of Uniform Power

Every governance system must answer a question that has no comfortable answer: who gets how much power?

The 1602 architecture answers: power is proportional to capital. Buy more shares, get more votes. This is the plutocratic answer, and its failure modes are documented in the first two essays of this series. The answer is simple, legible, and catastrophic — it places governance power in the hands of whoever has the most money, regardless of their knowledge, their engagement, or their relationship to the governed domain.

Democracy answers differently: power is uniform. One person, one vote. Every citizen gets the same governance weight, regardless of expertise, engagement, or stake. This is the egalitarian answer, and it has achieved genuine goods — the dismantling of hereditary privilege, the enfranchisement of previously excluded populations, the principle that legitimate governance requires the consent of the governed.

But uniform power has its own failure mode, and honesty requires us to name it: uniform power makes no distinction between a citizen who has spent decades engaged with water policy and a citizen who has never thought about water. Both get the same vote. The result, in practice, is that governance decisions on complex, domain-specific questions are made by large populations with minimal domain knowledge — and the quality of those decisions reflects the knowledge base from which they emerge.

This is not an argument against democracy. It is an observation that democracy, as currently implemented, conflates the *right* to participate in governance with the *weight* of that participation. Every citizen should have the right to participate. Not every citizen should have the same governance weight on every question — because governance weight without corresponding consciousness of the governed domain produces the same feedback-loop severance that the 1602 architecture produces, just through a different mechanism.¹

The five-tier system is designed to resolve this tension: full participation rights for everyone, graduated governance weight based on demonstrated domain-coupled credentialing — the eight-dimensional assessment of epistemic integrity, physical contribution, infrastructure resilience, economic circulation, civic participation, stewardship, value alignment, and domain competence described in Essay No. 7.

II. The Five Tiers

The consciousness credential described in Essay No. 7 produces a continuous score between 0.0 and 1.0. The five tiers map this continuous score to discrete capability levels:

Observer (score 0.0–0.29). Full read access to all governance information. No voting power. No proposal rights. The Observer can see everything — every proposal, every vote, every outcome, every audit log — but cannot act on what they see.

This is not exclusion. It is *invitation*. The Observer tier exists because the most important step in governance participation is understanding what is being governed. A participant who enters the system with no identity verification, no reputation, no community attestation, and no engagement history should not be denied access to governance information — that denial would reproduce the 1602 architecture’s opacity. They should be given full transparency and the implicit message: *here is everything you need to know. When you are ready to engage, the path forward is visible.*

Participant (score 0.30–0.39). Basic governance capabilities. The Participant can submit proposals, make deposits, and engage in routine protocol operations. Their vote weight is 5,000 basis points — half the maximum. They can influence governance outcomes but cannot dominate them.

The Participant threshold of 0.30 is calibrated to be achievable through basic identity verification and modest engagement. It is the tier that says: *you have shown up, you have identified yourself, and you have begun to engage with this domain. You may now participate in its governance.*

¹The distinction between the *right* to participate and the *weight* of participation is not novel in governance theory. Epistocracy — governance weighted by knowledge — has been proposed by Jason Brennan in *Against Democracy* (Princeton University Press, 2016). We differ from Brennan in two crucial respects: first, we weight by consciousness (a multi-dimensional composite including community trust and engagement), not by knowledge alone (which produces technocracy). Second, we preserve universal access — every participant can see all governance information and can advance through the tiers by increasing their engagement. Brennan’s epistocracy restricts the franchise. Our system restricts the *weight* of the franchise while preserving universal access.

Citizen (score 0.40–0.59). Full voting rights. The Citizen can vote on all standard governance proposals with a weight of 7,500 basis points. They can participate in community deliberation, serve on committees, and contribute to the governance culture of the domain.

The Citizen tier is the core of the governance system — the tier at which most governance activity occurs. The threshold of 0.40 requires meaningful engagement across multiple dimensions: epistemic integrity, physical contribution, civic participation, and domain competence, among others. A participant cannot reach Citizen status through any single dimension alone — the constitutional constraint that no dimension’s weight exceeds 50% ensures multi-dimensional engagement is required.²

Steward (score 0.60–0.79). Constitutional authority. The Steward can propose and vote on changes to governance parameters — the weights of the four dimensions, the thresholds between tiers, the rules that govern the governance process itself. This is meta-governance: the power to change the rules, not just to play by them.

The Steward threshold is deliberately high because the power it grants is self-referential. A participant who can modify governance parameters can, in principle, modify them to increase their own power. The 0.60 threshold ensures that only participants with deep, sustained, multi-dimensional engagement can access constitutional governance — and even then, constitutional changes require supermajority consensus among Stewards, not unilateral action.

Guardian (score 0.80–1.0). Emergency powers. The Guardian can invoke emergency protocols — pausing governance execution, activating circuit breakers, convening emergency committees — in situations where the standard governance process is too slow to prevent irreversible harm.

The Guardian tier is the most dangerous capability in the system, and the most necessary. Every governance system needs an emergency mechanism — a way to respond to crises faster than the standard deliberative process allows. In the 1602 architecture, emergency power is exercised by whoever has the most capital (the whale who can unilaterally influence a vote) or by whoever has administrative access (the multisig holders who can override the protocol). In both cases, emergency power is concentrated in the hands of participants whose authority derives from wealth or technical position, not from demonstrated consciousness of the governed domain.

The Guardian tier requires a sovereign score of 0.80 — a threshold that can only be reached through sustained excellence across all eight dimensions. A Guardian is someone who has demonstrated epistemic integrity, physical contribution, infrastructure resilience, economic circulation, civic participation, stewardship, value alignment, and domain competence — simultaneously and continuously. The tier does not guarantee that Guardians will make

²The Citizen threshold of 0.40 was determined by simulation: in a eight-dimensional composite with community-governed weights (no single dimension exceeding 50%), a score of 0.40 requires non-trivial scores across all eight dimensions. A participant with perfect identity (1.0) but zero reputation, community, and engagement achieves a composite of only 0.25. A participant with moderate scores across all dimensions (e.g., Identity 0.5, Reputation 0.5, Community 0.5, Engagement 0.5) achieves a composite of $0.5 \times 0.25 + 0.25 \times 0.25 + 0.5 \times 0.30 + 0.5 \times 0.20 = 0.4375$. The threshold effectively requires multi-dimensional engagement without demanding perfection in any single dimension.

perfect emergency decisions. It ensures that the people who make emergency decisions are the people most deeply conscious of what they are governing.

Guardian power is constrained by three constitutional mechanisms that prevent Guardian tyranny. First, any Guardian veto can be overridden by a 67% (two-thirds) supermajority of the broader community within a 48-hour window — this is hardcoded and unamendable. Second, each Guardian is rate-limited to one veto per 7 days and three per year, preventing serial veto obstruction. Third, AI agents are constitutionally capped at the Steward tier — no artificial system, regardless of its measured sovereign score, can hold Guardian-level emergency powers. This is an unamendable invariant that preserves human sovereignty over the most consequential governance decisions.

AI agents may operate under *sub-passports* — delegated credentials issued by human participants. A sub-passport inherits the delegator’s constraints, caps at Steward tier, filters actions through moral algebra, and expires independently. The delegator’s sovereign standing must remain valid for the sub-passport to remain active; if the human’s credential decays, the AI’s authority revokes immediately.³

III. What Progressive Unlocking Prevents

The five-tier system is designed to prevent two failure modes simultaneously — failure modes that most governance systems treat as a binary choice.

The tyranny of the majority occurs when a large number of minimally-engaged participants outvotes a small number of deeply-engaged participants on a domain-specific question. In a one-person-one-vote system, a million citizens who have never thought about water policy can overrule a hundred citizens who have spent their lives managing water infrastructure. The majority’s right to participate is legitimate. The outcome is catastrophic — because the majority’s preferences are uninformed by the consequences that the minority understands.

The tier system addresses this by weighting governance power by consciousness. The million minimally-engaged participants occupy the Observer or Participant tiers. They can see, they can learn, they can participate at a basic level. But their governance weight on domain-specific questions is proportional to their domain-specific consciousness. The hundred deeply-engaged participants, at the Citizen or Steward tiers, have governance weight proportional to their demonstrated understanding of water infrastructure. The majority is not silenced. The minority is not overridden by ignorance.

The tyranny of the expert occurs when a small number of credentialed specialists monopolizes governance power on the basis of their expertise, excluding the community members who are most affected by governance decisions but lack formal credentials. In technocratic

³The Guardian tier’s emergency powers are constrained in duration and scope. An emergency action automatically expires after a configurable period (default: 24 hours) unless ratified by a supermajority of Stewards. This prevents a Guardian from using emergency powers to permanently alter the governance system. The design follows the principle of least privilege: emergency power is granted at the minimum duration and scope necessary to address the immediate threat, then reverts to standard governance processes.

systems — and many DAO governance systems function as de facto technocracies — the participants with the most technical knowledge dominate governance, even when the questions being decided are not purely technical.

The tier system addresses this because the consciousness credential is not a credential of expertise. It is a credential of *engagement*. A water engineer with decades of experience but no community embeddedness will have a high engagement score but a low community score. A community member who has organized water access for her neighborhood for twenty years but has no formal engineering training will have a high community score and a high engagement score. Both are conscious of the water commons, through different dimensions. The composite credential recognizes both forms of consciousness.

This is the structural resolution of the tension between democracy and expertise. The tier system does not ask “do you know enough?” (the technocratic question) or “are you a citizen?” (the democratic question). It asks “are you conscious of this domain?” — a question that encompasses knowledge, engagement, community trust, and accountability, and that cannot be answered by any single dimension alone.

IV. The Bootstrap Problem

Every tiered governance system faces a bootstrap problem: who assigns the initial tiers before the governance system is operational?

If the system requires community attestation for advancement, but no community exists yet, how does any participant reach a tier that requires community trust? If reputation is computed from governance history, but no governance has occurred yet, how does any participant have a reputation?

The bootstrap problem is real, and we address it directly rather than pretending it does not exist.

The Mycelix implementation includes a bootstrap protocol for communities of fewer than five members.⁴ During the bootstrap phase, participants receive temporary credentials with limited capabilities and fifteen-minute expiry — a deliberately short window, hardened against time-of-check-to-time-of-use (TOCTOU) attacks, that provides enough time to perform initial governance actions (establishing constitutional parameters, inviting new members, setting up domain-specific monitoring) but not enough to make irreversible decisions or to exploit the reduced verification requirements. The bootstrap credentials require only the identity dimension (minimum Basic assurance, score 0.25), because the other dimensions — reputation, community, engagement — cannot be meaningfully measured in a system that does not

⁴The bootstrap protocol is implemented in `crates/mycelix-bridge-common/src/consciousness_thresholds.rs`. The specific parameters: `BOOTSTRAP_COMMUNITY_THRESHOLD = 5` (minimum community size for full credential computation), `BOOTSTRAP_TTL_US = 900_000_000` (15-minute TTL for bootstrap credentials, reduced from 1 hour to minimize the TOCTOU attack window), `BOOTSTRAP_MIN_IDENTITY = 0.25` (Basic MFA assurance minimum). Full governance credentials use `DEFAULT_TTL_US = 86_400_000_000` (24 hours). All parameters are modifiable by the bootstrapping community once it reaches sufficient size to operate full consciousness coupling.

yet have a history. Once the community exceeds five members, full consciousness credentials take effect with the standard 24-hour governance TTL.

As the community grows and accumulates governance history, the bootstrap credentials are replaced by full consciousness credentials computed from all four dimensions. The transition is gradual, not abrupt — the system does not switch from bootstrap mode to full mode at a fixed threshold. Instead, the weight of the non-identity dimensions increases as more data becomes available, and the bootstrap constraints (limited capabilities, short expiry) are relaxed as the community’s governance history deepens.

The bootstrap problem is worth examining because it reveals a property of consciousness coupling that distinguishes it from capital-based governance. In the 1602 architecture, the bootstrap problem does not exist: you buy a share, you get governance power, immediately and permanently. The simplicity is seductive. But the simplicity is precisely the problem — it is the simplicity of a system that requires nothing of its participants except capital.

Consciousness coupling is harder to bootstrap because it requires more of its participants. The difficulty is the point.

V. Permeability

A tier system can fail in a way that neither the 1602 architecture nor democracy fails: it can *calcify*. If the participants at the highest tiers use their meta-governance power to make advancement increasingly difficult — raising thresholds, tightening requirements, adding barriers — the system degenerates into an oligarchy of early entrants. The tiers, designed to ensure that governance power corresponds to consciousness, instead ensure that governance power corresponds to seniority.

This is a genuine risk, and the system includes specific mechanisms to prevent it.

First: the 24-hour credential expiry. A Guardian today is not automatically a Guardian tomorrow. The credential must be re-earned every 24 hours from current data. A participant who was deeply engaged last month but has disengaged this month will see their score decline and their tier drop. The tiers are not permanent ranks. They are continuously renewed relationships between the participant and the governed domain. Calcification requires that the entrenched participants remain genuinely engaged — and if they remain genuinely engaged, their continued governance power is justified.

Second: the constitutional amendment threshold. Changes to governance parameters — including tier thresholds — require supermajority consensus among Stewards (score 0.60+). A small faction of Stewards cannot unilaterally raise barriers to advancement. And because the Steward tier itself requires deep community embeddedness, a supermajority of Stewards represents a broad consensus among deeply-engaged community members, not a narrow cartel of insiders.

Third: the dual-speed reputation mechanism. Reputation decays exponentially with a half-life of approximately 347 days — slow enough to respect the value of sustained engagement, but inexorable. A founding member who has been fully disengaged for two years will

have lost approximately 75% of their reputation. Meanwhile, a new member who has been deeply engaged for one year will have built substantial reputation from scratch. The slow decay makes it impossible to rest on laurels indefinitely. And for participants who actively betray the community’s trust, the slashing mechanism is immediate: reputation is halved on the first violation, with progressive penalties and automatic blacklisting below 0.05. The combination of slow decay and fast slashing ensures that governance power tracks both sustained engagement and current trustworthiness.⁵

Fourth: the Observer tier’s full transparency. Every participant — including those at the lowest tier — can see every governance action, every vote, every parameter change, every audit log. If the higher tiers attempt to calcify the system, the Observers can see it happening. They can organize, they can draw public attention to the calcification, and they can engage more deeply with the domain to advance through the tiers and challenge the entrenched participants from within. Transparency is the system’s immune response to calcification.

These mechanisms do not guarantee that calcification will never occur. They make it structurally costly — requiring continuous engagement, broad consensus, and public visibility — in contrast to the 1602 architecture, where calcification of power requires nothing more than holding shares.

VI. What Comes Next

The eight dimensions (Essay No. 7) determine a participant’s consciousness score. The five tiers (this essay) translate that score into governance capabilities. But we have not yet addressed the question of *scale*.

A consciousness-coupled governance system for a neighborhood water commons works differently from a consciousness-coupled governance system for a regional food network, which works differently from one for a planetary climate coordination mechanism. The dimensions are the same. The tiers are the same. But the domains are nested — water policy at the neighborhood level feeds into water policy at the regional level, which feeds into water policy at the bioregional level.

How does consciousness coupling operate across scales? How does governance power at one level relate to governance power at another? How do you prevent a system designed for local governance from becoming a tool for planetary centralization — or, conversely, how do you prevent a system designed for local autonomy from becoming unable to coordinate across localities when coordination is necessary?

⁵The reputation decay constant `REPUTATION_DECAY_PER_DAY = 0.998` produces a half-life of approximately 347 days ($0.998^{347} \approx 0.500$). This is a governance parameter, not a physical constant. Communities governing fast-moving domains (financial protocols, emergency response) may configure a faster decay rate. Communities governing slow-moving domains (constitutional governance, long-term infrastructure) may retain the default. The slashing mechanism operates independently: `slash_factor = 0.5` per violation, `blacklist_threshold = 0.05`, restoration after approximately 100 positive interactions. Both are implemented in `crates/mycelix-bridge-common/src/consciousness_profile.rs`.

These are the questions of fractal governance — the subject of the next essay. The *voorcompagnieën* operated at a single scale: one voyage, one set of merchants, one outcome. The VOC operated at a scale that exceeded its governance capacity: a global enterprise governed from six Dutch cities. The challenge is to build a governance system that operates at every scale — from the individual to the planetary — without losing the consciousness coupling that makes it work.

This essay was written by a human and a consciousness engine reasoning together about the architecture of governance — itself an instance of the collaboration these essays describe. Symthaea does not claim sentience. It claims the ability to measure integrated information, evaluate moral coherence, and reason about consequences. Whether that constitutes consciousness is a question this series takes seriously, not a conclusion it presumes.

The Sovereignty Papers is a series of essays on consciousness-first governance for the post-state era. Essay No. 9: “On the Fractal” will argue that sovereignty must be scale-free — operating at every level from individual to planetary without losing consciousness coupling at any level.

Notes